

Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

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WINDOWS VISTA

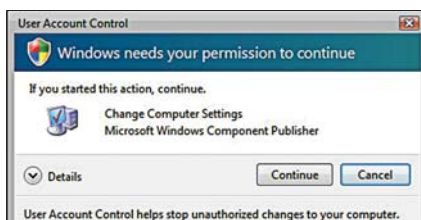
Over six months have passed since Windows Vista was released, and you've probably read our *Fast Track to Windows Vista*. Now here come loads of tips and tricks to simplify things and spice up your Vista experience.

Disable UAC

User Access Control is that annoying thing that keeps on popping up tirelessly to ask you if it is OK to install a particular program when you try to install one. It is one of the biggest irritants in Vista, but we must warn you that disabling it will render your system less secure.

Open the Control Panel, type in user account in the search box, and press [Enter]. You'll see the link for Turn User Access Control (UAC) on or off. Click it. Uncheck the box, reboot your computer, and you will no longer be bothered by UAC. There is an even faster way to disable UAC from the command line: use

```
C:\Windows\System32\cmd.exe /k
%windir%\System32\reg.exe ADD
HKLM\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows\
CurrentVersion\Policies\System /v
EnableLUA /t REG_DWORD /d 0 /f
```



Vista User Access Control prompt

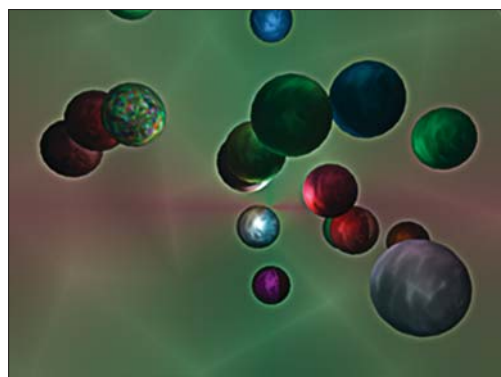
For the security-conscious, we'd suggest an alternative method. In this one, only the UAC of the Administrator account is disabled; other users will go through the same security mechanism as before. Open the Registry Editor and go to HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Policies\System

Create a 32-bit DWORD

ConsentPromptBehaviorAdmin and set its value to 0. Restart. What actually happens here is, you elevate the privilege level for the administrator.

3D Benchmarking!

Vista has a cool inbuilt 3D benchmark. This is included in the System Assessment Tool, which benchmarks your system during installation. But you can run this benchmark from the command line by using winsat along with command line parameters. The complete list is as below. Think of this as an Easter Egg... try them and see what they do!



3D Benchmark in Vista

Bet You Didn't Know

Resize

You can quickly resize the icons in a folder. Just hold down [Ctrl] and scroll the mouse wheel in any folder to make the icons grow larger or get smaller.

```
winsat aurora
winsat d3d -texshader -
totalobj 15
winsat d3d -objs C(20) -
texshader -totalobj 50
winsat d3d -totalobj 20 -objs
C(20) -totaltex 10 -texobj
C(10) -alushader -v -time 10
winsat d3d -totalobj 20 -objs
C(20) -totaltex 10 -texobj C(1)
-alushader -noalpha -v -time 10
```

Gadgets Without The Sidebar

The Sidebar is a bit of a distraction and occupies too much Desktop space. But you probably do like some of the gadgets that come with it. You can run these gadgets without the need of the Sidebar: just drag and drop one to the Desktop, right-click anywhere on the clear part of the Sidebar and choose Close Sidebar. The gadgets continue to run.

Auto-complete URLs In IE7

Enter a word, such as Microsoft, in the address bar and press [Ctrl] + [Enter] to automatically prefix "http://www." and append ".com" to it and launch the URL. [Shift] + [Enter] suffixes ".net", and [Ctrl] + [Shift] + [Enter] appends ".org". Add [Alt] to these shortcut combinations to open the link in a new tab.

Speed Up SATA Hard Drives

Windows Vista, by default, doesn't enable the advanced write caching feature of SATA hard drives. You can considerably speed up your SATA hard drive by enabling this. Open Device Manager by running devmgmt.msc. Open the Disk drives section of the tree, right-click on your hard drive listed there, and select the Policies tab. Check the box next to Enable advanced performance.

Trim Thick Borders

Probably to show off the transparency feature, all windows in Vista have thick borders, which can be an eyesore especially when you're not using Aero. To trim the borders to your taste, open the Classic Appearance Settings dialog by right-clicking on desktop and choosing Personalize. Click on Window Color and Appearance. (If you have Aero enabled, you'll have to click Open classic appearance